



SCHOOL FOR NRIs

Nawanshahar | PUNJAB

Culture
curry

California dreaming is easy, as is the living, but Indians there increasingly want the American accent to be tempered with home-grown values

■ By Ramesh Vinayak

When 15-year-old Sonia Parmar, a Canadian Indian, took admission in Kirpal Sagar Academy in Punjab in 2005, she was "terribly overwhelmed". Being transplanted to a foreign land that her parents had left two decades ago was a culture shock. Her knowledge of Punjabi was confined to a few words. And whatever little she knew about Indian culture was from Bollywood movies sub-titled in English she would see at home in Calgary. Two years on, she speaks Punjabi,

writes Gurmukhi with a flourish and takes pride in her desi culinary skills. "Schooling has helped me re-discover my cultural roots," says the eleventh grader who has also written four novels based on her cross-cultural experiences. "After all, my parents want me to grow up like an Indian girl," she says, sounding like the cinematic Simran of *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*.

Parmar is just one of a large number of expatriates who have been sent home to public schools in Punjab. It's a trend fuelled by the growing perception among

Punjabi NRIs that school education in India is culturally enriching, academically superior and economically easier on the wallet. In the last decade, there has been an exponential rise—estimated to quadruple—in the number of NRI students. Kirpal Sagar Academy is one such institution that offers culture-packed immerse-and-imbibe schooling. Part of the dollar-rich Doaba region with roughly two million expatriates, it has 45 NRIs from the US, Canada, Britain, Singapore, Thailand and Dubai. Principal of the academy, R.C. Sethi, says, "The rush is born out of the Punjabi expatriates' anxiety to insulate their wards from what they see as decadent western values."

Like Talwinder Singh, 16, who came in the eighth grade. "In California, I was a fat kid addicted to junk food," he says. In the last two years, he has become a new person. "I have lost weight and gained on Indian culture," he says with a grin.

\$1

TRILLION IS THE COMBINED WEALTH OF THE 20-MILLION STRONG NRI COMMUNITY, WHICH IS MORE THAN THE SIZE OF THE \$850-BILLION INDIAN ECONOMY